

Back to bash

Rohit Goswami · 2025-11-12 · tools · workflow · dots

Falling backwards into POSIX.

Background

I have been using `zsh` for over a decade now. For the most part, this has been across machines I largely have administrative control over. HPC systems are always a notable exception. Over the past half year, I've found myself working on dozens of machines where even `chezmoi` and `pixi~/~micromamba` workflows cannot comfortably bring `$HOME` ergonomics [^fn:1].

The road to `bash` is paved with `$SHELL` s

There are far too many today to bother enumerating, but in short order [^fn:2]:

`nushell`

Pleasant for many use-cases, the process of converting my dotfiles was fairly repetitive, and its incompatibility with `spack` made it a non-starter [^fn:3].

`fish`

Adopted to resolve the `spack` issue. However, I found I was the wrong audience for it; features like global, browser-based customization are not useful for my terminal-centric, `chezmoi` focused workflow [^fn:4].

`xonsh`

Ergonomic, and better than `subprocess` for scripts, but a non-starter in terms of being a good `$SHELL` [^fn:5]

For the most part I had resigned myself to `fish`. It was fast, needed very few plugins [^fn:6].

Eventually I came across [this post by Cody Hiar](#) on `ble.sh`, and decided to take the plunge and shift back. A driving force for this is also that most of my `dotfiles` focus on using `rust` equivalents of what used to purely `SHELL` specific themes / tools; e.g. `starship` over `powerline10k`.

Caveats

`ble.sh` is great but it isn't a catch-all solution. In particular, there are still inherent issues with using `bash` as a customized shell, due to concerns about clobbering settings from existing machines, e.g. `lua` module settings.

Conclusions

POSIX compatibility is here to stay on most machines. It is unlikely that this will change in the near future. To that end, it makes more sense to adaptively stick to `bash` and save my “strangeness budget“ [^fn:7] for new-fangled programming languages instead of shells [^fn:8].

hovered an intolerable 50ms, which I later found out was mostly due to `spack` [^fn:2]: Discounting many more ephemeral tests [^fn:3]: Fun for data pipelines and nicer multi-line commands [^fn:4]: Plus breaking POSIX for the features offered seemed like a bad trade-off [^fn:5]: i.e. barely any community support [^fn:6]: So fewer failure modes than my favorite `zsh` [^fn:7]: A concern I was recently re-sensitized to by [Luthaf] (<https://github.com/Luthaf/>) [^fn:8]: At any rate, I do relish not having to transform one-liners from `nushell` and friends back to `bash` to pass to co-workers.